

GREEN SHOOTS
Meera Chandran (extreme left) with members of the Forest First Samithi

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Happiness is when the saplings we plant become big trees, attracting a larger biodiversity of birds and several pollinators, triggering a cycle of restoration"

MEERA CHANDRAN, Founder, Forest First

inception, Forest First has restored over 300 acres of land in Wayanad and in Kodagu in Karnataka, and with years of fieldwork, the organisation has given a new lease of life to around 150 tree species in the Western Ghats.

Allowing native species to thrive does more than restore forests—it helps local wildlife and forest communities as well. The Lantana species, for example, kills plants on which herbivores thrive. Consequently, as the animals gradually leave the forest, predators often follow suit, which leads to man-animal conflict. A 2020 study conducted by the Wildlife Institute of India, Dehradun, says Lantana occupies 154,000 sq. km of forests (44 per cent by area) in India's tiger range. Restoring natural flora would bring wildlife back to the area and provide a safe home for endangered species. Additionally, edible fruits and seeds produced by the trees also help enhance the livelihoods of local communities. "After we remove invasive species, nature rebounds in just a few weeks of rain," says Chandran.

The Forest First Samithi also works actively with local tribes who have traditional knowledge of flora and fauna. The NGO hires 20 tribal people for 10 months a year. Support comes from corporates as well as crowdfunding platforms, and the money is passed on to communities who help the NGO with uprooting weeds and monitoring plants. "We have trained 45 people in restoration, thus supporting livelihoods in the villages around forests. We want to involve more indigenous people who can support our work," says Meera. She adds that she feels deeply happy when eco-restoration helps improve people's livelihoods.

In 2017, Forest First started working on restoration of sacred groves that are overrun by harmful weeds, and so far, it has saved nearly 20 acres of area. The group has also signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Kerala Forest Department to restore 200 acres of degraded forest land in critical animal habitat areas of Wayanad. Upon the completion of the project, these areas will not only become safe spaces for flora, fauna, wildlife and local communities but also beautiful sites for visitors to enjoy and experience native biodiversity. ■